

Chapter 2 — Socialism in Europe and the Russian Revolution

The one-line point: The French Revolution won **political** equality — one man, one vote. This chapter asks the obvious follow-up question: **what is a vote worth to a man who owns nothing?** In 1917, in one of the *least* industrialised countries in Europe, a party of socialists seized power to answer it — and spent the next thirty years discovering how far a state will go to build equality, and what it will destroy on the way.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → World History
Sub-discipline	History of political philosophy · revolution · economic history
Period	1815 – 1950s (core: 1898–1939)
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ Bolsheviks/Mensheviks, April Theses, Comintern, kulaks, Duma, Five Year Plans are all clean one-liners
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ ★ The syllabus names " political philosophies like communism, capitalism, socialism etc. — their forms and effect on the society. " This chapter <i>is</i> that line of the syllabus.
Also feeds	Polity ★ ★ (the word socialist in our Preamble came from <i>here</i> ; DPSPs; the Planning Commission's intellectual ancestry), Economy ★ ★ ★ (centralised planning, Five Year Plans — India borrowed the instrument directly), Essay ★ ★ ★ ★ (equality vs liberty; development vs freedom; means and ends), Ethics ★ ★ ★ (development achieved through repression), IR ★ ★ (Cold War origins, Comintern, non-alignment's backdrop)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ — the single most useful NCERT chapter for understanding twentieth-century politics
Overlaps with	Ch.1 (Marat's warning is the seed), Ch.3 (Nazism defined itself <i>against</i> this), Class 8 Ch.8 (1917's effect on Indian nationalists), Class 10, Class 12 Themes III

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Distinguish liberals, radicals and conservatives** on four axes without hesitation. ★ ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **State the socialist objection to private property** in NCERT's own causal terms. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Distinguish the visions** of Owen, Louis Blanc and Marx. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain Marx's argument** — capitalist, profit, worker, communist society. ★ ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe Russia's economy and society in 1914** with the key percentages. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain what made Russian peasants different** from other European peasants — **two** ways. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Distinguish Bolsheviks from Mensheviks**, and Social Democrats from Socialist Revolutionaries. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Narrate the 1905 Revolution** from the Putilov dismissals to the packed third Duma. ★ ★ ★

- ☐ **Explain how the First World War destroyed the autocracy.** ★★★★★
- ☐ ★★★★★ **Make two separate lists: February 1917 and October 1917** — events, actors, leaders, effects.
- ☐ **State the April Theses** — three demands. ★★★
- ☐ **List the immediate Bolshevik changes** after October. ★★★
- ☐ **Explain the Civil War** — reds, greens, whites, and the foreign backers. ★★
- ☐ **Explain collectivisation**, the kulaks, and the famine — with numbers. ★★★★★
- ☐ **Assess the USSR's global influence** and state the balanced verdict NCERT itself reaches. ★★★★★

1 The Age of Social Change

The French Revolution "*opened up the possibility of creating a dramatic change in the way in which society was structured.*" Before it, society was divided into **estates and orders**, and **the aristocracy and church controlled economic and social power**. Suddenly it seemed possible to change that.

In India, Raja Rammohan Roy and Derozio talked of the significance of the French Revolution — and NCERT adds a line worth noting: "*The developments in the colonies, in turn, **reshaped** these ideas of societal change.*" The traffic went **both ways**.

But not everyone wanted the same amount of change. Responses ran from "*some change is necessary, but gradually*" to "*restructure society radically.*"

⚠ **NCERT's methodological warning, and it is important:** "*We must remember that these terms **do not mean the same thing in all contexts or at all times.***" A nineteenth-century "liberal" is **not** what "liberal" means in today's newspapers.

🏛️ 1.1 Liberals, Radicals, Conservatives — the table to memorise

Question	LIBERALS	RADICALS	CONSERVATIVES
Religion	Wanted a nation that tolerated all religions (European states then favoured one — Britain: Church of England; Austria and Spain: Catholic Church)	—	—
Dynastic power	Opposed the uncontrolled power of dynastic rulers; wanted to safeguard individual rights against governments	Wanted government based on the majority of a country's population	Opposed radicals and liberals
Government form	Representative, elected parliamentary government, under laws interpreted by a well-trained judiciary independent of rulers and officials	—	—
★ ★ ★ The vote	NOT democrats. Did not believe in universal adult franchise . Felt men of property mainly should vote. Did not want the vote for women	Many supported women's suffragette movements	—
Privilege & property	Themselves often property owners and employers	Opposed the privileges of great landowners and wealthy factory owners. ★ Not against private property as such — but disliked its concentration in a few hands	—
Attitude to change	Change, yes	Change, radically	In the 18th century: generally opposed to change . By the 19th century: accepted some change was inevitable , but " <i>the past had to be respected and change had to be brought about through a slow process</i> "

🎯 ★ ★ ★ ★ ★ The one fact people get wrong: **nineteenth-century liberals were not democrats.** They wanted parliaments, rights and the rule of law — for **men of property**. If a question hinges on one distinction in this chapter, it is this one.

🏭 1.2 Industrial society and social change

*"It was a time when **new cities came up and new industrialised regions developed, railways expanded and the Industrial Revolution occurred.**"*

The problems industrialisation created:

- Men, women **and children** brought into factories
- **Long work hours, poor wages**
- **Unemployment common**, particularly during **times of low demand** for industrial goods
- **Housing and sanitation problems**, since towns were growing rapidly

Liberals and radicals looked for solutions — and their answer flowed from their own position:

Almost all industries were the PROPERTY OF INDIVIDUALS.
Liberals and radicals were themselves often PROPERTY OWNERS
and EMPLOYERS, who had made wealth through trade or industry.

So their prescription was:

- encourage such effort
- its benefits will follow IF the workforce is HEALTHY and citizens are EDUCATED
- opposed to privileges of birth, they believed in the value of INDIVIDUAL EFFORT, LABOUR and ENTERPRISE
- "If freedom of individuals was ensured, if the poor could labour, and those with capital could operate WITHOUT RESTRAINT, societies would develop."

★ ★ **Note the structure of this argument** — it is the **classical liberal / free-market position** in its original form, and you can quote it verbatim in an Economy or Essay answer on state versus market.

And in the early nineteenth century, "many working men and women who wanted changes in the world rallied around liberal and radical groups and parties." The workers did not start out as socialists.

Meanwhile: some nationalists, liberals and radicals became **revolutionaries** to overturn the governments established in Europe in **1815** — in **France, Italy, Germany and Russia**. **Giuseppe Mazzini**, the Italian nationalist, conspired to this end after 1815, and ★ "Nationalists elsewhere — **including India** — read his writings."

🚗 1.3 The coming of socialism — and how to hold the argument in your head

Picture an auto-rickshaw driver who does not own his auto. He drives twelve hours; at the end of the day he hands over a **fixed daily rent** to the owner and keeps what is left. The owner does no driving. If the driver works harder, most of the extra goes on fuel and the rent stays; if he falls ill, the rent still falls due. **The vehicle — not the driving — is what earns.**

Now ask the socialist's question: *should the thing that earns be owned privately at all?* That is the entire argument, and it is why the target is **property, not the rich person.**

NCERT's own statement of it:

*"Socialists were **against private property**, and saw it as **the root of all social ills** of the time. Why? **Individuals owned the property that gave employment but the propertied were concerned only with personal gain and not with the welfare of those who made the property productive.** So if **society as a whole rather than single individuals controlled property**, more attention would be paid to **collective social interests.**"*

🌱 Three socialist visions — do not blur them

Thinker	Dates	The vision
Robert Owen	1771–1858	"A leading English manufacturer " — sought to build a cooperative community called ★ New Harmony, in Indiana (USA) . Change through individual initiative
Louis Blanc	1813–1882	In France . Felt cooperatives could not be built on a wide scale through individual initiative alone — wanted the government to encourage cooperatives and replace capitalist enterprises . Cooperatives = " <i>associations of people who produced goods together and divided the profits according to the work done by members</i> "
Karl Marx (1818–1883) & Friedrich Engels (1820–1895)		Not cooperatives but overthrow . See below

🎯 **Prelims-grade distinction: Owen = voluntary community. Blanc = state-encouraged cooperatives. Marx = the workers must overthrow capitalism.** Three different answers to "how", one shared diagnosis.

🔧 Marx's argument, step by step

1. Industrial society is CAPITALIST.
2. CAPITALISTS own the capital invested in factories.
3. "The PROFIT of capitalists was PRODUCED BY WORKERS."
4. Therefore: "the conditions of workers could NOT IMPROVE as long as this profit was accumulated by PRIVATE capitalists."
- <- note: not a moral claim about greed, a STRUCTURAL claim about where profit comes from
5. So workers "had to OVERTHROW capitalism and the rule of private property."
6. They must construct "a radically socialist society where ALL PROPERTY WAS SOCIALLY CONTROLLED."
7. "This would be a COMMUNIST SOCIETY."
8. Marx "was convinced that workers would TRIUMPH in their conflict with capitalists. A communist society was the NATURAL SOCIETY OF THE FUTURE."

★★★ **Step 4 is the whole argument.** Learn to state it as NCERT does — *the profit of capitalists was produced by workers* — because it is the sentence every question on Marx is really testing.

📊 1.4 Support for socialism — how far it had got by 1914

Development	Detail
By the 1870s	Socialist ideas spread through Europe; socialists formed an international body — ★ the Second International
Workers' associations	In England and Germany , to fight for better living and working conditions; funds to help members in distress ; demands for reduced working hours and the right to vote
Germany	These associations worked closely with the ★ Social Democratic Party (SPD) and helped it win parliamentary seats
By 1905	Socialists and trade unionists formed a ★ Labour Party in Britain and a Socialist Party in France
★★★ The bottom line to 1914	***However, till 1914, socialists never succeeded in forming a government in Europe.** Their ideas shaped legislation, but governments "continued to be run by conservatives, liberals and radicals. "

🚩 The Paris Commune, 1871 — the rehearsal

- A popular uprising in Paris, March–May 1871, when the **town council (commune)** of Paris was taken over by a "**peoples' government**" of "*workers, ordinary people, professionals, political activists and others.*"
- Background: **growing discontent against the policies of the French state.**
- **Crushed by government troops** — but "*celebrated by Socialists the world over as a prelude to a socialist revolution.*"
- ★ **Two legacies to remember:**
 1. **The workers' RED FLAG** — the flag adopted by the *communards*.

2. **The Marseillaise** — "originally written as a war song in 1792" (**Chapter 1!**), it "became a symbol of the Commune and of the struggle for liberty."

🔗 **A lovely cross-link for an answer:** the same song that carried French volunteers to war against kings in 1792 was sung by Parisian workers against the French state in 1871. **Symbols outlive the causes that made them.**

2 Russia Before the Revolution

📖 2.1 The empire in 1914

Tsar Nicholas II ruled Russia and its empire. Besides the territory around Moscow, it included:

WEST: Finland, Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia, parts of POLAND, Ukraine, Belarus
EAST: stretched all the way to the PACIFIC
SOUTH: today's CENTRAL ASIAN STATES, plus Georgia, Armenia, Azerbaijan

RELIGION: majority = RUSSIAN ORTHODOX CHRISTIANITY (grown out of the GREEK Orthodox Church)
also CATHOLICS, PROTESTANTS, MUSLIMS, BUDDHISTS

★ ★ **Why this matters:** the "Russian" Revolution happened in a **multi-national, multi-religious empire**. That is why the nationalities question (and the *jadidists*, and Khiva) keeps returning later in the chapter.

📊 2.2 Economy and society — the numbers that matter

Fact	Figure
★ ★ ★ Share of population living from agriculture	about 85%
Comparison — France and Germany	between 40% and 50%
Russia's place in world trade	"a major exporter of grain " — cultivators produced for the market as well as for their own needs
Prominent industrial areas	★ St Petersburg and Moscow — " <i>Industry was found in pockets</i> "
The 1890s spurt	Many factories set up when the railway network was extended and foreign investment in industry increased . Coal production doubled; iron and steel output quadrupled
By the 1900s	In some areas factory workers and craftsmen were almost equal in number
Working day	15 hours in craft units and small workshops; 10 or 12 hours in factories
★ Women in the factory labour force by 1914	31% — paid between half and three-quarters of a man's wage

On regulation: *"Government supervised large factories to ensure **minimum wages and limited hours of work**. But **factory inspectors could not prevent rules being broken**."*

Workers were a *divided* social group — this is an exam favourite

DIVIDED BY ORIGIN some kept strong links with their villages
others had settled in cities permanently

DIVIDED BY SKILL "Metalworkers considered themselves
ARISTOCRATS among other workers. Their
occupations demanded more training and
skill..." — a St Petersburg metalworker

DIVIDED BY GENDER women = 31% of factory labour by 1914,
paid HALF to THREE-QUARTERS of a man's wage

DIVIDED IN DRESS AND MANNERS too.

...AND YET:
"Despite divisions, workers did UNITE TO STRIKE"
- textile industry, 1896-1897
- metal industry, 1902

Peasants — and the two things that made Russian peasants unusual

The common ground with workers: "Like workers, peasants too were *divided*." They were also **deeply religious**.

Difference #1 — no deference to the nobility.

*"But except in a few cases they had **no respect for the nobility**. Nobles got their power and position through their services to the Tsar, not through local popularity. This was unlike France where, during the French Revolution in Brittany, **peasants respected nobles and fought for them**."*

★ ★ ★ Consequently: * "In Russia, peasants **wanted the land of the nobles to be given to them**. Frequently, they **refused to pay rent and even murdered landlords**." — on a large scale in **south Russia in 1902**, and **all over Russia in 1905**.*

Difference #2 — the commune.

★ ★ ★ * "Russian peasants were different from other European peasants in another way. **They pooled their land together periodically and their commune (mir) divided it according to the needs of individual families**."*

 **Why difference #2 is the hinge of the whole chapter:** because it is why some Russian socialists argued **peasants were natural socialists** — they *already* redistributed land collectively. It is also, tragically, the practice that **Stalin's collectivisation would claim to be restoring while destroying**.

2.3 Socialism in Russia — the party map

First, the basic fact: ★ * "All political parties were illegal in Russia before 1914."*

RUSSIAN SOCIAL DEMOCRATIC WORKERS PARTY – founded 1898
by socialists "who respected Marx's ideas".
Because of government policing it operated ILLEGALLY:
set up a NEWSPAPER, mobilised workers, organised STRIKES.

split over TWO questions

QUESTION 1: are PEASANTS the revolutionary force?

SOCIALIST REVOLUTIONARY PARTY (formed 1900)
YES. The custom of periodically dividing land
makes peasants NATURAL SOCIALISTS; Russia can
become socialist FASTER than other countries.
Struggled for peasants' rights; demanded that
land belonging to NOBLES be transferred to them.

LENIN / SOCIAL DEMOCRATS

NO. "Peasants were not one united group."
Some poor, some rich; some worked as labourers,
"others were CAPITALISTS WHO EMPLOYED WORKERS."
Given this DIFFERENTIATION they could not all
be part of a socialist movement.

QUESTION 2:
who may join
the party?

BOLSHEVIKS (Lenin)
In a REPRESSIVE society like
Tsarist Russia the party must
be DISCIPLINED and must
CONTROL THE NUMBER AND
QUALITY of its members

MENSHEVIKS
The party should be
OPEN TO ALL
(as in GERMANY)

★★★★ Get this diagram right and half the chapter's confusions disappear. The
Bolshevik/Menshevik split is **not** about goals — it is about **party organisation in conditions of repression**.
And the SR/Social Democrat split is about **which class makes the revolution**.

💧 2.4 The 1905 Revolution

The starting condition: ★★ "Russia was an **autocracy**. Unlike other European rulers, even at the
beginning of the twentieth century, **the Tsar was not subject to parliament**."

Who wanted a constitution: Liberals campaigned to end this, working with **Social Democrats and Socialist Revolutionaries**, and with **peasants and workers**. They were supported by **nationalists (in Poland, for instance)** and in Muslim-dominated areas by ★ **jadidists** — "Muslim reformers within the Russian empire" who wanted **modernised Islam** to lead their societies.

The trigger chain:

1904 A bad year: prices of essential goods rose so fast that REAL WAGES DECLINED BY 20 PER CENT. Membership of workers' associations rose dramatically.

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The ASSEMBLY OF RUSSIAN WORKERS is formed in 1904.

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FOUR of its members are DISMISSED at the PUTILOV IRON WORKS -> call for industrial action

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Over the next few days OVER 110,000 WORKERS in St Petersburg STRIKE, demanding:

- reduction of the working day to EIGHT HOURS
- an increase in wages
- improvement in working conditions

|

BLOODY SUNDAY

The procession led by FATHER GAPON reaches the WINTER PALACE and is attacked by POLICE and COSSACKS. OVER 100 WORKERS KILLED, ABOUT 300 WOUNDED.

|

=> "started a series of events that became known as the 1905 REVOLUTION"

|

- STRIKES all over the country
- UNIVERSITIES CLOSED as student bodies staged walkouts complaining about the LACK OF CIVIL LIBERTIES
- "Lawyers, doctors, engineers and other middle-class workers established the UNION OF UNIONS and demanded a CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY."

What the Tsar conceded — and then took back:

Step	What happened
During 1905	The Tsar allowed the creation of an elected consultative Parliament — the DUMA
Briefly	A large number of trade unions and factory committees of factory workers existed
After 1905	Most committees and unions worked unofficially, since they were declared illegal; severe restrictions placed on political activity
★ ★ First Duma	Dismissed within 75 DAYS
★ ★ Second Duma	Re-elected, then dismissed within THREE MONTHS
★ ★ Third Duma	"He changed the voting laws and packed the third Duma with conservative politicians. Liberals and revolutionaries were kept out. "
His motive, stated plainly	"He did not want any questioning of his authority or any reduction in his power. "

🎯 The analytical point to carry into a Mains answer: 1905 shows that a **concession granted to survive a crisis, and withdrawn once the crisis passes, is worse than no concession at all** — it teaches every constitutionalist that the autocracy cannot be reformed, only removed. That lesson is what makes 1917 possible.

New word: ★ **Real wage** — "reflects the quantities of goods which the wages will actually buy." (A 20% fall in *real* wages in 1904 with money wages unchanged is exactly why prices matter more than pay slips.)

🌐 2.5 The First World War destroys the autocracy

The alliances:

CENTRAL POWERS	vs	THE ALLIES
Germany		France
Austria		Britain
Turkey		Russia
		(later ITALY and ROMANIA)

"Each country had a GLOBAL EMPIRE and the war was fought OUTSIDE Europe as well as in Europe."

The slide from popular to poisonous:

Stage	Detail
Initially	"In Russia, the war was initially popular and people rallied around Tsar Nicholas II"
Then	"As the war continued, the Tsar refused to consult the main parties in the Duma . Support wore thin"
Anti-German feeling	★ St Petersburg — a German name — was renamed PETROGRAD
The court	Tsarina Alexandra's German origins and poor advisers, especially a monk called RASPUTIN , made the autocracy unpopular

Why the eastern front was different — and worse:

*"In the **west**, armies fought **from trenches** stretched along eastern France. In the **east**, **armies moved a good deal and fought battles leaving large casualties. Defeats were shocking and demoralising.**"*

1914–1916 Russia's armies LOST BADLY in Germany and Austria
 By 1917 OVER 7 MILLION CASUALTIES
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 As they retreated, the Russian army DESTROYED CROPS AND BUILDINGS to prevent the enemy living off the land
 |
 -> OVER 3 MILLION REFUGEES inside Russia
 -> "The situation DISCREDITED the government and the Tsar. SOLDIERS DID NOT WISH TO FIGHT SUCH A WAR."

And the war wrecked the economy:

- Russia's **own industries were few**, and the country was **cut off from other suppliers of industrial goods by German control of the Baltic Sea**.
- **Industrial equipment disintegrated more rapidly in Russia than elsewhere in Europe**.
- ★ **By 1916, railway lines began to break down**.
- **Able-bodied men called up ⇒ labour shortages ⇒ small workshops producing essentials shut down**.
- **Large supplies of grain sent to feed the army ⇒ "For the people in the cities, *bread and flour became scarce.*"**
- ★★ **"By the winter of 1916, riots at bread shops were common."**

★★★★ **This is the answer to "Why did the Tsarist autocracy collapse in 1917?"** Not one cause but a **convergence**: an autocracy that refused to share power (1905 → packed Duma → refusal to consult the Duma in war), a war it could not fight (7 million casualties, 3 million refugees), an economy it could not run (broken railways, closed workshops, no bread), and an army that had stopped believing in it. **Note the sequence — the regime lost the army last, and that is the moment it fell.**

3 February 1917 — The Revolution Nobody Organised

The city as a map of the conflict

PETROGRAD, WINTER 1917

RIGHT BANK of the River Neva

WORKERS' QUARTERS

Factories

LEFT BANK

the FASHIONABLE AREAS

the WINTER PALACE

official buildings

the palace where the DUMA met

"The layout of the city seemed to EMPHASISE THE DIVISIONS among its people."

Conditions: food shortages **deeply felt in the workers' quarters**; the winter **very cold — exceptional frost and heavy snow**; and parliamentarians **wishing to preserve elected government were opposed to the Tsar's desire to dissolve the Duma**.

The eight days

Date (Feb 1917)	Event
22 February	A lockout at a factory on the right bank
23 February	Workers in fifty factories call a sympathy strike . ★ <i>"In many factories, women led the way to strikes. This came to be called the International Women's Day."</i> * Demonstrating workers cross from the factory quarters to the centre of the capital — the Nevskii Prospekt
★★ (note)	<i>"At this stage, no political party was actively organising the movement."</i>
	The government imposes a curfew ; demonstrators disperse by evening
24–25 February	They come back . The government calls out cavalry and police
Sunday 25 February	★ The government suspends the Duma . Politicians speak out against the measure
26 February	Demonstrators return in force to the streets of the left bank
27 February	Police Headquarters ransacked . Streets throng with people raising slogans about ★ bread, wages, better hours and democracy . The government calls out the cavalry again — ★★★ "However, the cavalry REFUSED TO FIRE on the demonstrators." An officer is shot at a regiment's barracks and three other regiments mutiny, voting to join the striking workers
That evening	Soldiers and striking workers gather to form a ★ "soviet" or "council" in the same building as the Duma met — the PETROGRAD SOVIET
28 February	A delegation goes to see the Tsar; military commanders advise him to abdicate
★★ 2 March	The Tsar ABDICATES
After	Soviet leaders and Duma leaders form a PROVISIONAL GOVERNMENT . Russia's future <i>"would be decided by a constituent assembly, elected on the basis of universal adult suffrage"</i>

★★★★ Three things about February that questions turn on:

1. **No political party organised it**. It began as a **lockout and a bread strike**.
2. **Women led it — on International Women's Day**.

3. **It succeeded the moment the army changed sides.** The cavalry's refusal to fire on 27 February is the actual end of the Romanov dynasty. Everything before that was protest; that was revolution.

Box 1 — Marfa Vasileva, and how a strike actually starts

At the **Lorenz telephone factory**, on Women's Day, women workers had presented **red bows** to the men. Then **Marfa Vasileva, a milling machine operator, stopped work and declared an impromptu strike.**

The foreman *"informed the management and **sent her a loaf of bread. She took the bread but refused to go back to work.**"* Asked again why, she replied: ★ ★ ★ ***"I cannot be the only one who is satiated when others are hungry."***

Women from another section gathered around her, **all the women ceased working, then the men downed tools, and the entire crowd rushed onto the street.**

 **Keep this quotation.** It is the perfect illustrative anecdote for an essay on solidarity, and it makes the abstract point — *that a personal remedy is not a solution to a general injustice* — in eleven words spoken by a machine operator.

3.1 After February — the dual power

Who was influential in the Provisional Government: ★ **army officials, landowners and industrialists** — *"But the liberals as well as socialists among them worked towards an elected government."*

Immediate changes: restrictions on public meetings and associations removed; "Soviets", like the Petrograd Soviet, were set up everywhere — *"though no common system of election was followed."*

April 1917 — Lenin returns and states the April Theses

In April 1917, the Bolshevik leader Vladimir Lenin returned to Russia from his exile. He and the Bolsheviks had **opposed the war since 1914.** Now he felt **it was time for soviets to take over power.**

THE APRIL THESES — THREE DEMANDS

1. THE WAR BE BROUGHT TO A CLOSE
2. LAND BE TRANSFERRED TO THE PEASANTS
3. BANKS BE NATIONALISED

PLUS: he argued the BOLSHEVIK PARTY should RENAME ITSELF the COMMUNIST PARTY "to indicate its new radical aims".

Reaction inside his own party:

"Most others in the Bolshevik Party were INITIALLY SURPRISED... They thought that the time was NOT YET RIPE for a socialist revolution and the Provisional Government NEEDED TO BE SUPPORTED."

-> "But the developments of the subsequent months changed their attitude."

 **Peace, Land, Bread** is the popular slogan you will see elsewhere; NCERT's three theses are **war, land, banks.** Learn NCERT's version — that is what the paper will match.

Summer 1917 — the Provisional Government loses the country

In the cities	In the countryside
Workers' movement spread ; in industrial areas factory committees formed which began questioning the way industrialists ran their factories	Peasants and their Socialist Revolutionary leaders pressed for a redistribution of land
Trade unions grew in number	Land committees formed to handle this
Soldiers' committees formed in the army	★ "Encouraged by the Socialist Revolutionaries, peasants seized land between July and September 1917 "
★ In June, about 500 Soviets sent representatives to an ALL RUSSIAN CONGRESS OF SOVIETS	
The government's response: as it "saw its power reduce and Bolshevik influence grow, it decided to take stern measures " — it resisted attempts by workers to run factories and began arresting leaders . ★ Bolshevik demonstrations in July 1917 were sternly repressed; many Bolshevik leaders had to go into hiding or flee	

4 October 1917 — The Revolution That Was Organised

⚠ The single most important contrast in this chapter: **February was spontaneous and leaderless; October was planned, dated and secret**. If you write only one distinguishing sentence, write that one.

Lenin FEARS the Provisional Government will set up a DICTATORSHIP.

SEPTEMBER He begins discussions for an UPRISING.
Bolshevik supporters in the ARMY, SOVIETS and
FACTORIES are brought together.

16 OCT Lenin persuades the PETROGRAD SOVIET and the
BOLSHEVIK PARTY to agree to a SOCIALIST SEIZURE
OF POWER.
A MILITARY REVOLUTIONARY COMMITTEE is appointed
by the Soviet under LEON TROTSKII to organise
the seizure.
"The date of the event was KEPT A SECRET."

24 OCT THE UPRISING BEGINS.
- Sensing trouble, PM KERENSKII leaves the city
to summon troops
- At DAWN, pro-government military men seize the
buildings of TWO BOLSHEVIK NEWSPAPERS
- Pro-government troops sent to take over TELEPHONE
and TELEGRAPH offices and protect the WINTER PALACE
- In swift response the MILITARY REVOLUTIONARY
COMMITTEE orders its supporters to SEIZE GOVERNMENT
OFFICES and ARREST MINISTERS
- Late in the day the ship AURORA SHELLS THE
WINTER PALACE; other vessels sail down the Neva
and take over military points
- BY NIGHTFALL the city is under the committee's
control and the ministers have SURRENDERED

At the ALL RUSSIAN CONGRESS OF SOVIETS in Petrograd,
THE MAJORITY APPROVES the Bolshevik action.

BY DECEMBER Uprisings in other cities; HEAVY FIGHTING especially
in MOSCOW; the Bolsheviks control the
MOSCOW-PETROGRAD area.

Box 2 — the calendar trap (a classic Prelims item)

☆☆☆ Russia followed the **Julian calendar** until **1 February 1918**, then changed to the **Gregorian** calendar used everywhere today. **Gregorian dates are 13 days ahead.** So by our calendar:

- the "**February**" Revolution took place on **12 March**
- the "**October**" Revolution took place on **7 November**

That is why the USSR celebrated the October Revolution in November. A question can be built on this alone.

5 What Changed After October

The immediate measures

Domain	Change
Industry and banks	★ Most industry and banks NATIONALISED in November 1917 — <i>"the government took over ownership and management"</i>
Land	★ Declared social property; peasants allowed to seize the land of the nobility
Housing	In cities, Bolsheviks enforced the partition of large houses according to family requirements
Titles	Banned the use of the old titles of aristocracy
Uniforms	New uniforms designed for army and officials after a clothing competition in 1918 — when the ★ Soviet hat (<i>budeonovka</i>) was chosen
Party name	The Bolshevik Party renamed the Russian Communist Party (Bolshevik)

The Constituent Assembly — the decisive moment

NOV 1917 The Bolsheviks CONDUCT the elections to the CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY ...
... and FAIL TO GAIN MAJORITY SUPPORT.

JAN 1918 The Assembly REJECTS Bolshevik measures.
LENIN DISMISSES THE ASSEMBLY.

His justification: "He thought the ALL RUSSIAN CONGRESS OF SOVIETS was MORE DEMOCRATIC than an assembly elected in UNCERTAIN CONDITIONS."

MAR 1918 Despite opposition by their political allies, the Bolsheviks make PEACE WITH GERMANY at BREST LITOVSK.

AFTER The Bolsheviks became THE ONLY PARTY to participate in elections to the All Russian Congress of Soviets, which became the PARLIAMENT of the country.
"RUSSIA BECAME A ONE-PARTY STATE."

And the apparatus that followed:

- Trade unions kept under party control.
- ★ The secret police — called the CHEKA first, and later OGPU and NKVD — punished those who criticised the Bolsheviks.
- **Culture:** *"Many young writers and artists rallied to the Party because it stood for **socialism and for change**. After October 1917, this led to **experiments in the arts and architecture**. But many became **disillusioned because of the censorship the Party encouraged**."*

★★★★★ **This paragraph is the most quotable in the chapter for a balanced answer.** A revolution against a tsar who dissolved Dumas ended by dissolving an elected Constituent Assembly within two months. Note it honestly — and note Lenin's reasoning honestly too, because that is how you write a Mains answer rather than a pamphlet.

🏠 Box 3 — two views of October in the countryside

A peasant account (Fedor Belov)	A landowning family's letter
News reached the village the following day and "was greeted with enthusiasm ; to the peasants it meant free land and an end to the war ." The landowner's manor house was looted , stock farms " requisitioned ", the vast orchard cut down and sold to the peasants for wood , farm buildings torn down and left in ruins , and the land distributed among the peasants	"The 'coup' happened quite painlessly, quietly and peacefully ... The first days were unbearable... I must say the chairman behaves correctly and even politely. We were left two cows and two horses. The servants tell them all the time not to bother us. 'Let them live...' — and there are rumours some villages want to evict the committees and return the estate

★ ★ ★ **Use these two together.** NCERT deliberately prints both because "*the revolution in the countryside*" has no single truth: the same event was **liberation** and **dispossession**, and in the second account it was also **oddly courteous**. This is exactly the kind of source-pairing that earns marks in a Mains answer about perspective in history.

✂ 5.1 The Civil War, 1918–20

TRIGGER: When the Bolsheviks ordered LAND REDISTRIBUTION, the Russian army began to BREAK UP -- soldiers, mostly peasants, "wished to go home for the redistribution and DESERTED".

THE SIDES

REDS = the BOLSHEVIKS
GREENS = the SOCIALIST REVOLUTIONARIES
WHITES = PRO-TSARISTS

"Non-Bolshevik socialists, liberals and supporters of autocracy condemned the Bolshevik uprising. Their leaders moved to SOUTH RUSSIA and organised troops."

DURING 1918–19: greens and whites controlled MOST of the Russian empire.
BACKED BY: FRENCH, AMERICAN, BRITISH and JAPANESE troops -- "all those forces who were worried at the growth of socialism in Russia."

RESULT ON THE GROUND: "looting, banditry and FAMINE became common."

Why the Bolsheviks won — NCERT gives you two reasons and one qualification:

- ★ ★ "Supporters of private property among 'whites' **took harsh steps with peasants who had seized land.** Such actions led to the **loss of popular support for the non-Bolsheviks.**" — the whites destroyed their own base.
- "They succeeded due to **cooperation with non-Russian nationalities and Muslim jadidists.**"
- ⚠ **The qualification:** "Cooperation did **not** work where **Russian colonists themselves turned Bolshevik. In Khiva, in Central Asia, Bolshevik colonists brutally massacred local nationalists in the name of defending socialism.** In this situation, many were confused about what the Bolshevik government represented."

By January 1920 the Bolsheviks controlled most of the former Russian empire.

The nationalities settlement: "Partly to remedy this, most non-Russian nationalities were given **political autonomy** in the ★ **Soviet Union (USSR)** — the state the Bolsheviks created from the Russian empire in **DECEMBER 1922**. But since this was combined with **unpopular policies that the Bolsheviks forced the local government to follow** — like the **harsh discouragement of nomadism** — attempts to win over different nationalities were **only partly successful.**"

New words: Autonomy — the right to govern themselves. **Nomadism** — the lifestyle of those who do not live in one place but **move from area to area to earn their living**.  **Hold on to "the harsh discouragement of nomadism"** — you will meet the *identical* colonial instinct in **Chapter 5 of this book**, where the British do the same thing to Indian pastoralists. **Two opposed ideologies, one shared hostility to people who move.**

Source B — two views of the Revolution in Central Asia

M.N. Roy, <i>Memoirs</i> (1964) — Indian revolutionary, founder of the Mexican Communist Party , prominent Comintern leader in India, China and Europe	A Kazakh leader, 1919
The Kirgiz youth " <i>had heard of the Revolution, which had overthrown the Tsar and driven away the Generals who conquered the homeland of the Kirgiz. So, the Revolution meant that the Kirgiz were masters of their home again. 'Long Live the Revolution' shouted the Kirgiz youth... The whole tribe joined.</i> "	*"The Kirghiz welcomed the first revolution (February) with joy and the second revolution with consternation and terror ... The first freed them from Tsarist oppression and strengthened their hope that autonomy would be realised. The second was accompanied by violence, pillage, taxes and the establishment of dictatorial power ... Once a small group of Tsarist bureaucrats oppressed the Kirghiz. Now the same group of people... perpetuate the same regime. "*

★★★★ This pairing is gold for an answer on "revolution and empire." For subject peoples, the question was never *socialism or capitalism* — it was **whether the centre had changed its ideology or only its vocabulary**.

6 Making a Socialist Society

5.2 Planning

Element	Detail
During the civil war	Industries and banks kept nationalised ; peasants permitted to cultivate the land that had been socialised ; confiscated land used to demonstrate what collective work could be
★★★★ The instrument	"A process of centralised planning was introduced. Officials assessed how the economy could work and set targets for a five-year period . On this basis they made the FIVE YEAR PLANS ."
First two Plans	★ 1927–1932 and 1933–1938; the government fixed all prices to promote industrial growth
★★ The result	*"Centralised planning led to economic growth . Industrial production increased (between 1929 and 1933 by 100 per cent in the case of oil, coal and steel). New factory cities came into being. "*

 ★★★★★ **Direct link to your Economy syllabus: India's Five Year Plans (from 1951) and the Planning Commission** take their instrument straight from here — Nehru visited the USSR and wrote about it (Box 5). When you are asked about Indian planning's intellectual origins, **this is the origin**.

The human cost of the pace

- **Magnitogorsk:** the construction of a **steel plant achieved in three years**. "*Workers lived hard lives and the result was **550 stoppages of work in the first year alone**.*"
- In living quarters, "*in the wintertime, at 40 degrees below, people had to climb down from the fourth floor and dash across the street in order to go to the toilet.*"

What the state *did* deliver

- An extended schooling system developed.
- Arrangements made for factory workers and peasants to enter universities.
- ★ Crèches established in factories for the children of women workers.
- Cheap public health care provided.
- Model living quarters set up for workers.
- ⚠️ *"**The effect of all this was uneven, though, since government resources were limited.**"*

Source C — a 13-year-old's letter, 1933: *"**I want to study very much, but I cannot go to school. I had some old boots, but they are completely torn... there stands before us the task of **studying, studying and studying**. That is what Vladimir Ilich Lenin said. **But I have to stop going to school...** I have to go to work in a factory, to prevent the family from starving. Dear grandfather, **I am 13, I study well and have no bad reports. I am in Class 5.**"***

🌀 A society that told children "*study, study, study*" and could not keep a Class 5 student in boots. **That sentence — the promise and the shortfall in one letter — is worth quoting whole.**

5.3 Stalinism and collectivisation

THE PROBLEM (1927–28)

Towns face "an ACUTE PROBLEM OF GRAIN SUPPLIES".
The government FIXED the prices at which grain must be sold
-- and "the PEASANTS REFUSED TO SELL their grain to government buyers at these prices."

STALIN'S DIAGNOSIS (he headed the party after Lenin's death)
"Rich peasants and traders in the countryside were HOLDING STOCKS in the hope of higher prices. SPECULATION had to be stopped and supplies CONFISCATED."

1928 Party members tour the grain-producing areas, supervising ENFORCED GRAIN COLLECTIONS and raiding 'KULAKS' -- "the name for WELL-TO-DO PEASANTS".

THE SECOND ARGUMENT (as shortages continued)
"Grain shortages were partly due to the SMALL SIZE OF HOLDINGS. After 1917, land had been given over to peasants. These small-sized peasant farms COULD NOT BE MODERNISED."

THE CONCLUSION
"To develop modern farms, and run them along industrial lines with machinery, it was necessary to ELIMINATE KULAKS, TAKE AWAY LAND FROM PEASANTS, and establish STATE-CONTROLLED LARGE FARMS."

FROM 1929 -- COLLECTIVISATION
The Party FORCED ALL PEASANTS to cultivate in collective farms (KOLKHOZ). The bulk of land and implements were transferred to the ownership of the collective farms.
Peasants worked the land and the kolkhoz profit was shared.

What happened:

Consequence	Detail
Resistance	"Enraged peasants resisted the authorities and destroyed their livestock "
★ ★ Livestock	"Between 1929 and 1931 , the number of cattle fell by ONE-THIRD "
Punishment	"Those who resisted collectivisation were severely punished. Many were deported and exiled "
★ ★ ★ The peasants' own argument	"they were not rich and they were not against socialism . They merely did not want to work in collective farms for a variety of reasons"
The concession	"Stalin's government allowed some independent cultivation , but treated such cultivators unsympathetically "
★ ★ ★ ★ The outcome	*"In spite of collectivisation, production did not increase immediately. In fact, the bad harvests of 1930–1933 led to one of the most devastating famines in Soviet history when OVER 4 MILLION DIED ."*
★ ★ ★ The purges	*"Many within the Party criticised the confusion in industrial production... and the consequences of collectivisation. Stalin and his sympathisers charged these critics with conspiracy against socialism . Accusations were made throughout the country, and by 1939, over 2 MILLION were in prisons or labour camps . Most were innocent of the crimes, but no one spoke for them . A large number were forced to make false confessions under torture and were executed — several among them talented professionals "

Source D (official report, Ukraine, 19 March 1930): "mass insurrections of the peasantry have taken place... **Between 1st February and 15th March, 25,000 have been arrested... 656 have been executed, 3,673 have been imprisoned in labour camps and 5,580 exiled.**" ⚠️ Read the framing, not just the numbers. The report blames "**distortions of the Party's line by a section of the lower ranks**" — never the policy itself. **The line is always correct; only its execution can be faulty.** That rhetorical move is itself a finding about how such systems work.

Source E — Frebenev, an independent cultivator: *"From 1932, heavy taxes have been levied on me that I have found impossible... all my property was registered: my **horse, cow, calf, sheep with lambs, all my implements, furniture and my reserve of wood**... and they sold the lot for the taxes. In 1936, they sold two of my buildings... **the kolkhoz bought them.**"* 🎯 Note the mechanism precisely: he was not expropriated by decree. **He was taxed until he had to sell, and the collective farm was the buyer.** Squeeze, then acquire.

New words: Deported — forcibly removed from one's own country. **Exiled** — forced to live away from one's own country.

7 The Global Influence of the Revolution

🌐 What it did abroad

Development	Detail
The mixed reception	"Existing socialist parties in Europe did not wholly approve of the way the Bolsheviks took power — and kept it "
★ But	"the possibility of a workers' state fired people's imagination across the world"
New parties	Communist parties formed in many countries — e.g. the Communist Party of Great Britain
Colonial outreach	"The Bolsheviks encouraged colonial peoples to follow their experiment "
★ Institutions	The Conference of the Peoples of the East (1920) ; the Bolshevik-founded ★ COMINTERN (1919) — "an international union of pro-Bolshevik socialist parties"; and the Communist University of the Workers of the East
By 1939	"By the time of the outbreak of the Second World War, the USSR had given socialism a global face and world stature "

IN Box 5 — In India

- **Several Indians attended the Communist University.**
- ★ **By the mid-1920s the Communist Party was formed in India**, its members in touch with the Soviet Communist Party.
- ★★ **Jawaharlal Nehru and Rabindranath Tagore** took an interest in the Soviet experiment and **visited Russia**; both **wrote about Soviet socialism**.
- **In Hindi**, **R.S. Avasthi** wrote *Russian Revolution, Lenin, His Life and His Thoughts* (1920–21) and later *The Red Revolution*; **S.D. Vidyalkar** wrote *The Rebirth of Russia* and *The Soviet State of Russia*. "There was much that was written in **Bengali, Marathi, Malayalam, Tamil and Telugu**."

Shaukat Usmani, arriving in 1920: "For the first time in our lives, we were seeing **Europeans mixing freely with Asians**... we were convinced that we had come to **a land of real equality**... **No barriers of caste or religion** hindered them from mixing freely with one another. **Every soul was transformed into an orator**."*

Rabindranath Tagore, from Russia in 1930: "The whole place belongs to the workers... those who lived in the background for ages have come forward in the open today... I thought of the peasants and workers in my own country... only a decade ago they were as **illiterate, helpless and hungry as our own masses**... Who could be more astonished than an unfortunate Indian like myself to see how they had removed the mountain of ignorance and helplessness in these few years."*

★★★★ **NCERT then asks the question you should always ask of such sources: "What did the writers FAIL TO NOTICE?"** Read Usmani and Tagore **against** Source C (the boy with torn boots), Source D (25,000 arrests) and Source E (the confiscated cultivator). **Both sets are true**. For a colonised Indian, the sight of **Europeans and Asians as equals** and **workers walking in the open** was genuinely revolutionary — and that is exactly why the famine and the labour camps were not what he came looking for. **This is the best available illustration of how the observer's own condition shapes what a source can see.**

NCERT's own final verdict — memorise the shape of it

★★★★★ **"Yet by the 1950s it was acknowledged **within the country** that the style of government in the USSR was not in keeping with the ideals of the Russian Revolution... A backward country had become a great power. Its industries and agriculture had developed and the poor were being fed. BUT it had DENIED THE ESSENTIAL FREEDOMS TO ITS CITIZENS and carried out its developmental projects THROUGH REPRESSIVE POLICIES. By the end of the twentieth century, the international reputation of the USSR as a socialist country **had declined** though it was recognised that socialist ideals still enjoyed respect among its people. But in each country the ideas of socialism were rethought in a variety of different ways."**

THE BALANCE SHEET -- write your answer in exactly this shape

ACHIEVED	COST
A backward country became a GREAT POWER	Essential freedoms DENIED to citizens
Industry and agriculture DEVELOPED	Development carried out through REPRESSIVE policies
The poor WERE BEING FED	4 million dead in the famine
Schooling, creches, cheap health care, universities opened to workers and peasants	2 million in prisons/camps by 1939
	One-party state, censorship, secret police

● Prelims traps

Trap	The truth
"Nineteenth-century liberals believed in universal adult franchise"	★ They were NOT democrats. Only men of property should vote; not women
"Radicals opposed private property"	No — they opposed its concentration in a few hands . Socialists opposed private property
"Bolsheviks and Mensheviks differed on socialism"	They differed on party organisation — Lenin wanted a disciplined, controlled membership ; Mensheviks wanted it open to all, as in Germany
"The Socialist Revolutionaries were the workers' party"	They were the peasants' party (formed 1900), and argued peasants were natural socialists . Lenin disagreed , citing differentiation among peasants
"The February Revolution was led by the Bolsheviks"	★★ **At this stage, no political party was actively organising the movement.** Women led the strikes on International Women's Day
"The Tsar was overthrown in October 1917"	He abdicated on 2 March 1917 (February Revolution). October removed the Provisional Government
"The October Revolution happened in October"	By the Gregorian calendar it was 7 November ; February was 12 March . Russia switched calendars on 1 February 1918
"Lenin's April Theses demanded peace, land and bread"	NCERT's three: ★ end the war · transfer land to peasants · nationalise banks (plus renaming the party)
"The Bolsheviks won the Constituent Assembly election"	★ They FAILED to gain a majority (Nov 1917); Lenin DISMISSED the Assembly in January 1918
"Reds, whites and greens: greens were pro-Tsarist"	Reds = Bolsheviks · Greens = Socialist Revolutionaries · Whites = pro-Tsarists. Foreign backers: French, American, British, Japanese
"Kulaks were landless labourers"	Well-to-do peasants
"Kolkhoz was the Soviet secret police"	Kolkhoz = collective farm. Secret police = Cheka → OGPU → NKVD
"Collectivisation raised production immediately"	★ It did not. Bad harvests 1930–33 → famine, over 4 million dead ; cattle fell by one-third 1929–31
"The USSR was created in 1917"	★ December 1922
"Comintern was formed in 1917"	1919
"The First Five Year Plan began in 1929"	★ 1927–1932 was the first; 1933–1938 the second. Collectivisation began 1929
"Bloody Sunday was in 1917"	★ 1905 — Father Gapon's procession at the Winter Palace; 100+ killed, ~300 wounded
"The Duma was a real parliament"	An elected consultative parliament; 1st dismissed in 75 days, 2nd in 3 months, 3rd packed with conservatives after the voting laws were changed

● Mains angles

- ★★★★★ **"Why did the Tsarist autocracy collapse in 1917?"** — Structure it as a **convergence**: (i) an autocracy that would not share power (1905 → packed third Duma → refusal to consult the Duma in war); (ii) a war it could not fight (7 million casualties, 3 million refugees, scorched-earth retreat); (iii) an economy it could not run (Baltic blockade, railways breaking down by 1916, workshops closing, bread riots by winter 1916); (iv) a discredited court (Alexandra, Rasputin); (v) **and finally the army changed sides** — the cavalry's refusal to fire on 27 February.
- ★★★★★ **Two lists: February vs October** (NCERT's own Question 4 — and the most likely thing you will be asked to write):

	FEBRUARY 1917	OCTOBER 1917
Nature	Spontaneous, no party organising	Planned in secret, date withheld
Trigger	A lockout ; bread , wages, hours	A decision by the Petrograd Soviet, 16 October
Who	Women workers , then all workers, then soldiers	Bolshevik supporters in the army, soviets and factories
Leaders	No identifiable leadership	Lenin ; Trotskii heading the Military Revolutionary Committee
Method	Strikes, demonstrations, mutiny	Seizure of government offices, arrest of ministers, the Aurora shelling the Winter Palace
Outcome	Tsar abdicates (2 March) ; Provisional Government formed; promise of a constituent assembly on universal adult suffrage	Provisional Government overthrown ; soviet power ; nationalisation of industry, banks and land
Longer effect	Restrictions lifted; soviets set up everywhere	One-party state , Constituent Assembly dismissed, civil war , and eventually the USSR

- ★★★★★ "A backward country had become a great power... but it had denied the essential freedoms to its citizens." Evaluate. — The best essay/GS1 question here. Use the **balance sheet** above, and be genuinely two-sided.
- ★★★ Explain the socialist critique of private property, and distinguish the visions of Owen, Blanc and Marx.
- ★★★ **Collectivisation: examine whether it was an economic necessity or a political choice.** — Stalin's stated reasons (speculation; holdings too small to modernise) vs the peasants' own answer ("*we are not rich and we are not against socialism; we merely do not want to work in collective farms*") vs the outcome (famine, cattle destroyed, production not raised).
- ★★★ **Assess the global influence of the Russian Revolution, with particular reference to India.** — Comintern, the Communist University, the CPI by the mid-1920s, Nehru and Tagore, the vernacular writing; then the honest counterpoint of what Indian visitors did not see.
- ★★ **How did the First World War transform domestic politics in the belligerent states?** — Russia as the case study; carries directly into **Chapter 3** and Germany.

Cross-links to build now

- Ch.1** — **Marat's warning** ("*they will do the same to the other owners of wealth*") is the seed of this chapter; the **Marseillaise** reappears at the Paris Commune.
- Ch.3** — Nazism defines itself **against** communism; the German **SPD** and communists are its first targets.
- Ch.5 of this book** — "*the harsh discouragement of nomadism*" in Central Asia is the **same instinct** as the British hostility to Indian pastoralists.
- Class 8 Ch.8** — "*in 1917, there was a revolution in Russia. News about peasants' and workers' struggles*" reached Indian nationalists; this is why the Congress after 1917 sounds different from the Congress of the 1880s.
- Economy** — **Five Year Plans and centralised planning**, adopted by India in 1951.
- Polity** — the word "**SOCIALIST**" in our Preamble (42nd Amendment, 1976) descends from this tradition.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Suffragette movement	A movement to give women the right to vote
Real wage	Reflects the quantities of goods which the wages will actually buy
Jadidists	Muslim reformers within the Russian empire
Autonomy	The right to govern themselves
Nomadism	Lifestyle of those who move from area to area to earn their living
Deported	Forcibly removed from one's own country
Exiled	Forced to live away from one's own country
Liberals	Wanted religious tolerance, individual rights, elected parliamentary government and an independent judiciary — but not universal franchise
Radicals	Wanted government based on the majority of the population; supported women's suffrage; opposed concentration of property
Conservatives	Accepted that some change was inevitable, but the past had to be respected and change made slowly
Socialism	The view that private property is the root of social ills and that society as a whole should control property
Capitalist	One who owns the capital invested in factories ; in Marx's account, their profit is produced by workers
Communist society	A society in which all property is socially controlled
Second International	The international body formed by socialists in the 1870s to coordinate their efforts
Mir	The Russian peasant commune , which periodically pooled and divided land by family need
Duma	The elected consultative parliament conceded by the Tsar in 1905
Soviet	A council of workers and soldiers
Bolsheviks	Lenin's group — a disciplined party with controlled membership
Mensheviks	Favoured a party open to all , as in Germany
April Theses	Lenin's 1917 demands: end the war, land to peasants, nationalise banks
Comintern	The Bolshevik-founded (1919) international union of pro-Bolshevik socialist parties
Kulaks	Well-to-do peasants
Kolkhoz	Collective farm
Cheka / OGPU / NKVD	The successive names of the secret police
Budeonovka	The Soviet hat , chosen in a clothing competition in 1918

60-Second Recap

1. **Liberals** — religious tolerance, individual rights, elected parliament, independent judiciary — **but property-based franchise and no vote for women. Radicals** — government by the **majority**, pro-suffragette, against **concentration** of property but not property itself. **Conservatives** — change must be **slow** and respect the past.

2. **Industrialisation** brought long hours, poor wages, unemployment, and housing and sanitation crises. Liberals and radicals — often employers themselves — prescribed **individual effort, enterprise, a healthy workforce, educated citizens, and capital operating without restraint**.
3. ★ **Socialists blamed private property itself:** owners cared for **personal gain**, not for those who made property productive. **Owen** = New Harmony, Indiana; **Louis Blanc** = government-encouraged cooperatives; **Marx & Engels** = workers must **overthrow** capitalism, because **the profit of capitalists is produced by workers**.
4. By the **1870s** the **Second International**; **SPD** in Germany; **Labour Party (Britain)** and **Socialist Party (France)** by **1905** — but ★ **no socialist government anywhere in Europe till 1914**. The **Paris Commune (1871)** left the **red flag** and the **Marseillaise**.
5. **Russia 1914:** Tsar **Nicholas II**; **85% agricultural** (France/Germany 40–50%); a **major grain exporter**; industry in **pockets (St Petersburg, Moscow)**; **women 31%** of factory labour at **half to three-quarters** of a man's wage; workers **divided** by origin, skill, gender — yet **struck** in 1896–97 and 1902.
6. ★ **Russian peasants were different twice over:** they had **no respect for nobles** (unlike Brittany in the French Revolution) and **wanted their land** — killing landlords in **1902** and **1905**; and they **pooled land periodically**, the commune (**mir**) dividing it by family need.
7. **All parties illegal before 1914. RSDLP 1898; Socialist Revolutionary Party 1900** (peasants as natural socialists) vs **Lenin** (peasants are **differentiated**); **Bolsheviks** (disciplined, controlled membership) vs **Mensheviks** (open to all).
8. ★ **1905:** real wages fall **20%** in 1904 → four men dismissed at the **Putilov Iron Works** → **110,000 strike** for an **eight-hour day** → **Bloody Sunday** (Father Gapon; **100+ killed, ~300 wounded**) → strikes, university walkouts, the **Union of Unions** demanding a constituent assembly → the **Duma** conceded, then the **first dismissed in 75 days**, the **second in three months**, the **third packed** after the voting laws were changed.
9. **The First World War:** initially popular; **7 million casualties by 1917**; scorched-earth retreat → **3 million refugees**; **Baltic blockade, railways breaking down by 1916**, workshops closed, grain sent to the army → ★ **bread riots by the winter of 1916. St Petersburg** → **Petrograd; Alexandra and Rasputin** discredit the court.
10. ★ ★ **February 1917:** 22 Feb lockout → 23 Feb strike in **fifty factories, women leading**, on **International Women's Day** → **no party organising** → 25 Feb **Duma suspended** → 27 Feb police HQ ransacked; **the cavalry refuses to fire**; regiments mutiny; the **Petrograd Soviet** forms → **2 March: the Tsar abdicates** → **Provisional Government**.
11. **April Theses: end the war · land to the peasants · nationalise the banks** — and rename the party **Communist**. His own party was **initially surprised**.
12. **Summer 1917:** factory committees, growing trade unions, soldiers' committees, **500 soviets** at the **All Russian Congress** in June; peasants **seize land July–September**; the government **represses the Bolsheviks in July**.
13. ★ ★ **October 1917:** decided **16 October**; **Trotskii's Military Revolutionary Committee**; uprising **24 October**; **Kerenskii** leaves; the **Aurora** shells the Winter Palace; ministers surrender; approved by the **All Russian Congress**; Moscow–Petrograd secured **by December**. (*Gregorian: 7 November.*)
14. **After October:** industry and banks **nationalised (Nov 1917)**; land **social property**; large houses **partitioned**; aristocratic titles **banned**; the **budeonovka**; the Constituent Assembly election **lost**, and the Assembly **dismissed in January 1918**; peace at **Brest Litovsk (March 1918)**; ★ **a one-party state**, with **Cheka/OGPU/NKVD** and **censorship**.
15. **Civil War 1918–20:** **reds** vs **greens (SRs)** and **whites (pro-Tsarists)**, the latter backed by **French, American, British and Japanese** troops. Whites lost popular support by **punishing peasants who had seized land**; Bolsheviks cooperated with **non-Russian nationalities and jadidists** — except at **Khiva**,

where Bolshevik colonists **massacred local nationalists**. ★ USSR created **December 1922**, with **political autonomy** for nationalities but **harsh discouragement of nomadism**.

16. ★ **Planning: Five Year Plans 1927–32 and 1933–38**, all prices fixed; **oil, coal and steel output up 100% between 1929 and 1933**; **Magnitogorsk** built in three years with **550 stoppages in the first year**. Plus **extended schooling, university entry for workers and peasants, factory crèches, cheap health care, model quarters** — *"uneven, since government resources were limited."*
17. ★ ★ **Collectivisation from 1929**: grain crisis 1927–28 → raids on **kulaks** in 1928 → forced **kolkhoz** → peasants destroy livestock (**cattle down one-third, 1929–31**), resisters **deported and exiled** → **production did not rise; bad harvests 1930–33** → famine, **over 4 million dead**; and by 1939 **over 2 million in prisons or labour camps, most innocent**.
18. **Globally: Comintern (1919)**, the **Conference of the Peoples of the East (1920)**, the **Communist University**; the **CPI by the mid-1920s**; **Nehru and Tagore** wrote about Soviet socialism. ★ **NCERT's verdict**: *"A backward country had become a great power... but it had denied the essential freedoms to its citizens and carried out its developmental projects through repressive policies."*

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Which of the following did **nineteenth-century liberals** support? (i) Religious tolerance (ii) Universal adult franchise (iii) An independent judiciary (iv) Votes for women — **(i) and (iii) only. Liberals were not democrats.**
2. The Bolshevik–Menshevik split was over — *the **organisation of the party**: Lenin wanted a **disciplined party controlling the number and quality of its members** in a repressive society; the Mensheviks wanted it **open to all, as in Germany**.*
3. Consider: (i) The February Revolution was organised by the Bolshevik Party. (ii) The Tsar abdicated on 2 March 1917. (iii) Women workers led the strikes of 23 February. — **(ii) and (iii) only. "No political party was actively organising the movement."**
4. *Kolkhoz, kulak, mir* — match with: collective farm / well-to-do peasant / village commune. — **kolkhoz = collective farm; kulak = well-to-do peasant; mir = the commune that pooled and divided land.**
5. Lenin's **April Theses** demanded — *an **end to the war, transfer of land to the peasants, and nationalisation of banks**.*
6. The USSR was formed in — **December 1922**. (Comintern: **1919**; collectivisation: from **1929**; first Five Year Plan: **1927–32**.)
7. Bloody Sunday is associated with — **1905, the procession led by Father Gapon to the Winter Palace; over 100 killed and about 300 wounded.**

Mains style

8. Why did the Tsarist autocracy collapse in 1917? **(250 words)** ★
9. Make two lists — the main events and effects of the **February** Revolution, and of the **October** Revolution. Who was involved in each, who led each, and what was the impact of each on Soviet history? **(250 words)** ★ *the most likely question in this chapter*
10. In what ways was the working population in Russia different from that in other countries in Europe before 1917? **(150 words)**

11. What were the main changes brought about by the Bolsheviks immediately after the October Revolution? **(150 words)**
12. *"A backward country had become a great power... but it had denied the essential freedoms to its citizens."*
Critically evaluate the Soviet experiment. **(250 words)** ★
13. Examine Stalin's collectivisation programme — its rationale, its methods and its consequences. **(250 words)**
14. Assess the global influence of the Russian Revolution, with particular reference to India. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Distinguish liberals, radicals and conservatives on religion, franchise, property and the pace of change.
- State Marx's argument in five steps.
- Give three ways Russian society in 1914 differed from western Europe, with figures.
- Explain the Bolshevik–Menshevik split, and the Social Democrat–SR split.
- Narrate 1905 from the Putilov dismissals to the third Duma.
- Give the February timeline from 22 February to 2 March.
- State the April Theses and the October sequence, with the two calendars.
- List the immediate post-October measures and the date the Constituent Assembly was dismissed.
- Give the collectivisation numbers: cattle, famine deaths, prison population.